

About Validation Determination Standard

Governing the Difference Between Validation Results and What

Those Results Legitimately Demonstrate

Validation produces results.

Results produce information.

But information does not automatically produce a legitimate validation conclusion.

A validation process may generate thousands of measurements, observations, tests, comparisons, simulations, expert assessments, statistical outputs, and system responses.

The methodological question remains:

What do those results actually demonstrate?

Validation Determination Standard (VDTS) is the eighth Parent Standard of **VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture**, governing the transformation of the complete governed validation record into a bounded, traceable, and methodologically legitimate Validation Determination.

VDTS addresses one fundamental question:

What does the governed validation record legitimately demonstrate about the Validation Object?

Why Validation Determination Standard Exists

Validation conclusions are often treated as if they emerge automatically from validation results.

They do not.

Between:

Result

and:

Conclusion

there is an interpretive governance layer.

A test may produce a number.

A simulation may produce a scenario.

An expert may produce an assessment.

An AI system may produce a classification.

A measurement may cross a threshold.

Several tests may contradict each other.

Some criteria may pass.

Some may fail.

Some may remain impossible to determine.

The validation process must establish how these different findings become a legitimate conclusion.

VDTS governs that transition.

Results Are Not Determinations

VALIDOS® deliberately separates:

Validation Result

from: **Validation Determination**

A Validation Result is an output produced during validation execution.

A Validation Determination is a governed conclusion derived from the legitimate validation record.

Therefore:

Validation Result ≠ Validation Determination

This distinction prevents raw outputs from being treated as self-interpreting proof.

The Determination Layer

The preceding VALIDOS® Parent Standards establish the validation basis and execute the validation process.

The lifecycle has reached:

Validation Object

↓

Validation Purpose & Scope

↓

Validation Criteria



Validation Method



Validation Evidence Fitness



Validation Source Reliability



Validation Execution



Validation Determination

VDTS is the point where VALIDOS® asks what the completed validation process has actually established.

Determination Begins With Governed Execution

VDTS does not interpret every result generated during validation.

It begins from execution that has already passed through execution governance.

The preceding Validation Execution Standard establishes whether execution was:

- complete,
- conditionally complete,
- incomplete,
- conformant,
- conditionally conformant,
- non-conformant,
- invalid,
- Determination Ready,
- or Determination Blocked.

This prevents VDTS from constructing certainty from execution that cannot legitimately support it.

Determination Must Remain Connected to the Validation Object

Every determination must remain attached to the exact Validation Object examined.

This may include:

- object identity,
- version,
- configuration,
- state,
- release,
- population,
- environment,
- time,
- or other material boundaries.

A conclusion about:

Object Version 3.2

does not automatically become a conclusion about:

Object Version 4.0

Validation Determination therefore remains object-bound.

Determination Must Remain Purpose-Bound

The meaning of a validation result depends partly upon why validation was performed.

A validation designed to determine:

technical performance

does not automatically establish:

safety

regulatory compliance

ethical acceptability

or:

operational suitability

unless those questions were included within the governed Validation Purpose and Criteria.

Therefore:

Validated for Purpose A ≠ Validated for Purpose B

Determination Cannot Exceed Validation Scope

One of the most important VDTs boundaries is: **Determination Scope ≤ Legitimately Executed Validation Scope**

If validation examined:

- one population,
- one jurisdiction,
- one environment,
- one system version,
- one operating range,
- or one defined use case,

the resulting determination should not silently expand beyond those boundaries.

Validation Depth Matters

Not all validation provides the same level of assurance.

An exploratory validation and a high-assurance validation may examine similar questions but support different strengths of conclusion.

VDTs therefore preserves the relationship between:

Validation Depth

and:

Determination Strength

A conclusion cannot legitimately claim greater methodological assurance than the validation process achieved.

Criterion-Level Determination Comes First

VDTs does not jump immediately from execution outputs to an overall label.

It first asks what the governed record demonstrates relative to each applicable Validation Criterion.

A criterion may be:

Satisfied

Conditionally Satisfied

Not Satisfied

or:

Not Determinable

This creates a structured determination layer beneath any overall conclusion.

Criterion Satisfied

A criterion is Satisfied where the governed validation record provides sufficient legitimate basis to demonstrate that the required condition has been met within the applicable scope and conditions.

The conclusion remains traceable to:

- criterion,
 - method,
 - evidence,
 - sources,
 - execution,
 - outputs,
 - thresholds,
 - and limitations.
-

Criterion Not Satisfied

A criterion is Not Satisfied where the governed validation record sufficiently demonstrates that the required condition has not been met.

This is fundamentally different from missing information.

VALIDOS® therefore establishes:

No Evidence of Satisfaction ≠ Evidence of Non-Satisfaction

Criterion Not Determinable

Sometimes the correct methodological conclusion is:

We cannot determine this.

This may occur because of:

- insufficient evidence,
 - incomplete execution,
 - unresolved conflict,
 - excessive uncertainty,
 - execution limitations,
 - source limitations,
 - or another methodological constraint.
-

VALIDOS® treats **Not Determinable** as a legitimate governed outcome.

It prevents uncertainty from being artificially converted into success or failure.

Conditional Satisfaction

Reality is often conditional.

A Validation Object may satisfy a criterion:

- only within a defined operating range,
- only for a specific population,
- only in a specific environment,
- only while a control remains active,
- only for a specific system version,
- or only subject to another explicit condition.

VDTS preserves those conditions.

Therefore:

Conditionally Satisfied ≠ Unconditionally Satisfied

Critical Criteria Cannot Disappear Into Averages

Suppose a system satisfies 99 criteria but fails one criterion governing catastrophic failure.

A simple numerical average might suggest: **99% validated**.

Methodologically, that conclusion may be meaningless.

VDTS therefore preserves the governance significance of critical and mandatory criteria.

A critical failure cannot automatically be neutralized by many low-consequence successes.

Aggregation Is a Governance Problem

Multiple criterion outcomes eventually need to be interpreted together.

But VALIDOS® establishes:

Aggregation ≠ Averaging

Criteria may be:

- mandatory,
- critical,
- supporting,
- hierarchical,
- conditional,
- exclusionary,
- dependent,
- or independently required.

VDTS therefore governs how criterion outcomes may legitimately contribute to an overall Validation Determination.

Weights Must Not Be Invented After Results Are Known

Some validation systems legitimately use weighted criteria.

But weighting creates methodological risk if weights are changed after results become visible.

A validator could otherwise increase the importance of favorable results and reduce the importance of unfavorable ones.

VDTS therefore requires weighting structures, where used, to remain methodologically justified and traceable.

Contradictory Results Must Remain Visible

Real validation rarely produces perfectly uniform evidence.

One test may support satisfaction.

Another may suggest failure.

Different environments may produce different results.

Different sources may conflict.

Repeated measurements may vary.

VDTS does not permit contradiction to disappear merely because one conclusion is more convenient.

Instead, contradiction becomes a governed determination condition.

Determination Conflict

A **Determination Conflict** exists where legitimate validation findings support materially incompatible conclusions.

The appropriate response may include:

- additional analysis,
- additional validation,
- method comparison,
- evidence reassessment,
- source reassessment,
- scope separation,
- conditional determination,
- or an Indeterminate Validation Determination.

VALIDOS® does not require every conflict to be forcibly resolved.

Sometimes the existence of unresolved conflict is itself the correct methodological finding.

Uncertainty Must Survive Determination

Validation cannot always eliminate uncertainty.

Uncertainty may originate from:

- measurement,
- evidence,
- sources,
- sampling,
- methodology,
- execution,
- object variability,
- environmental variability,
- statistical uncertainty,
- or conflicting findings.

VDTS ensures that material uncertainty survives the transition from results to conclusion.

Uncertainty Does Not Mean Validation Failure

A legitimate determination may contain uncertainty.

The governance question is:

Is the remaining uncertainty compatible with the Validation Purpose, Criteria, Depth, consequence, and intended determination?

Low-consequence validation may tolerate uncertainty that would be unacceptable in a high-consequence environment.

Evidence Conditions Propagate Forward

Evidence qualified earlier under VALIDOS® may carry limitations.

For example:

Conditionally Fit Evidence

should not silently become:

Unrestricted Determination Evidence

when VDTs begins.

The limitations of evidence remain attached to the conclusions that depend upon it.

Source Conditions Also Propagate Forward

The same principle applies to sources.

A source classified as usable only with:

Independent Corroboration

cannot legitimately become the sole unrestricted basis for a Validation Determination unless that condition was resolved.

Therefore:

Source Reliability Conditions → Determination Conditions

where materially relevant.

Execution Limitations Propagate Forward

The Validation Execution Standard may permit determination while preserving residual limitations.

VDTs consumes those limitations.

It does not erase them.

For example:

If one execution portion is valid only within a reduced scope, the determination supported by that portion must remain within that scope.

Positive Validation Determination

A **Positive Validation Determination** means that the governed validation record sufficiently demonstrates satisfaction of the required Validation Criteria for the defined scope and conditions.

It does not mean:

The object is universally valid.

It does not mean:

The object will remain valid forever.

It does not mean:

Every possible use is authorized.

It means that the governed validation event supports a positive conclusion within its legitimate boundaries.

Conditional Validation Determination

A **Conditional Validation Determination** means that the validation record supports a positive conclusion only under explicit conditions, restrictions, assumptions, or scope boundaries.

These conditions are part of the determination.

Removing them changes the meaning of the conclusion.

Negative Validation Determination

A **Negative Validation Determination** means that the governed validation record sufficiently demonstrates non-satisfaction of one or more criteria whose governance significance prevents a positive determination for the applicable scope.

Negative determination must remain evidence-based.

It cannot be inferred merely from missing information.

Indeterminate Validation Determination

An **Indeterminate Validation Determination** means that VALIDOS® does not possess sufficient governed basis to establish either a positive or negative overall conclusion.

This is not methodological weakness.

In some situations it is the most accurate possible conclusion.

Therefore:

Indeterminate ≠ Failed

It means:

The governed evidence does not justify certainty.

Partial Validation Determination

Complex systems do not always produce one uniform validation conclusion.

A system may be:

- positively determined for one subsystem,
- conditionally determined for another,
- negatively determined for another,
- and indeterminate for another.

Where those boundaries can be reliably separated, VDTs supports Partial Validation Determination.

This preserves reality rather than forcing complexity into one misleading label.

Hierarchical Determination

Large systems may require determination across several levels.

For example:

Criterion → Component → Subsystem → System

or:

Test → Capability → Domain → Overall Object

VDTs permits hierarchical determination where each level remains traceable to the level beneath it.

A Positive Determination Is Not a Validation State

This is one of the most important architectural boundaries.

VDTs answers:

What did this governed validation process demonstrate?

The next Parent Standard asks:

What formal Validation State should the Validation Object now hold?

Those are different questions.

A determination is a conclusion from a validation event.

A state is a governed lifecycle condition associated with the object.

Therefore:

Validation Determination ≠ Validation State

A Positive Determination Is Also Not Reliance Authorization

Even a strong Positive Validation Determination does not automatically authorize operational reliance.

An organization may still need to consider:

- risk,
- jurisdiction,
- operational context,
- authority,
- deployment conditions,
- time,
- system change,
- intended use,
- or revalidation requirements.

Therefore:

Positive Validation Determination ≠ Authorization to Rely

Reliance belongs to the final VALIDOS® governance layer.

Determination Authority Matters

Some validation contexts require an identifiable authority to issue or approve the formal determination.

That authority may be:

- human,
- institutional,
- delegated,
- automated under governed rules,
- or hybrid.

VDTS does not create external legal authority.

It governs the methodological authority relationship used to transform validation findings into a formal determination.

Human Determination

Human judgment may be necessary where:

- evidence is complex,

- criteria interact,
- uncertainty is material,
- findings conflict,
- or contextual interpretation is required.

Human involvement does not remove the need for traceability.

A human determination should still remain connected to its governed basis.

Automated Determination

Some validation contexts permit deterministic or automated determination.

For example:

If A, B, and C are satisfied and no exclusion condition exists → Positive Determination

Automation can improve consistency.

But the determination logic itself must remain governed.

A machine should not silently create new aggregation rules during determination.

AI-Assisted Determination

AI may assist with:

- evidence synthesis,
- criterion mapping,
- conflict detection,
- uncertainty identification,
- comparison,
- traceability,
- and determination preparation.

But AI assistance must remain bounded by the governed Validation Determination framework.

AI should not transform methodological interpretation into an untraceable black box.

Determination Must Be Reconstructable

A qualified reviewer should be able to move backward from:

Overall Validation Determination

to:

Criterion Determinations

to:

Execution Outputs

to:

Execution Activities

to:

Evidence and Sources to:

Validation Method

to:

Validation Criteria

to:

Validation Purpose & Scope

to:

Validation Object

This creates the conclusion traceability chain of VALIDOS®.

Determination Records Matter

The formal Validation Determination Record should preserve sufficient information to establish:

What was concluded?

About what?

Against which criteria?

Within which scope?

From which execution?

Using which evidence and sources?

With which uncertainty?

With which conflicts?

Under which limitations?

Under which conditions?

By what determination authority?

This prevents a later statement such as:

“The system was validated.”

from existing without methodological meaning.

“Validated” Is Not Enough

One of the central problems VALIDOS® addresses is the compression of complex validation into one word:

Validated

That word may conceal:

- what was validated,
- for what purpose,
- against what criteria,
- with what method,
- using what evidence,
- under which conditions,
- at what depth,
- with what uncertainty,
- for which version,
- and for how long.

VDTS therefore replaces ambiguous validation claims with governed determination structure.

Determination Can Change

A Validation Determination is based upon the governed information available at a particular point in time.

New information may emerge.

For example:

- previously missing execution records,
 - newly discovered deviations,
 - evidence integrity problems,
 - source reliability changes,
 - methodological errors,
 - incorrect criterion interpretation,
 - or new information about the Validation Object.
-

VDTS therefore allows determination reassessment.

Reassessment Must Preserve History

When a determination changes, the previous determination should not simply disappear.

VALIDOS® preserves:

Original Determination → New Information → Reassessment → Revised Determination

This creates methodological history.

Determination Suspension

Where serious new uncertainty emerges before reassessment is complete, a determination may require suspension.

Suspension means that the previous conclusion should not continue to be represented as fully current while its basis is materially uncertain.

Determination Withdrawal

Where the methodological basis of a determination is fundamentally destroyed, the determination may require withdrawal.

Examples may include:

- wrong Validation Object,
- invalid execution,
- compromised critical evidence,
- major source failure,
- or fundamental methodological error.

Withdrawal protects the validation record from continuing to communicate a conclusion that can no longer be defended.

Position Within VALIDOS®

Validation Determination Standard is the eighth Parent Standard of
VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture.

Its architectural position is:

**Validation Object → Validation Purpose & Scope → Validation Criteria
→ Validation Method → Validation Evidence Fitness → Validation
Source Reliability → Validation Execution → Validation Determination**

→ Validation State → Validation Reliance & Revalidation

The first seven Parent Standards establish what was validated and whether the validation process was legitimate.

VDTS establishes:

What that legitimate validation process demonstrated.

The next Parent Standard can then govern:

What formal validation condition the Validation Object should hold as a result.

Relationship to Other OOF® Architectures

VDTS operates alongside complementary OOF® governance architectures.

GOA™ may establish authority, delegation, scope, and governance conditions relevant to determination.

OBIDENTITY® may preserve Validation Object identity, origin, ownership, provenance, and continuity.

INTEGROS® may provide integrity conditions affecting evidence, execution records, and determination artifacts.

ORA™ may establish operational-reality conditions relevant to interpretation.

AGA™ may establish accountability for determination roles and decisions.

RIS™ may inform the strength and assurance required for high-consequence determinations.

AIG®, CLIA®, MGIA™, and ASGA™ may provide specialized criteria and governance conditions where AI behavior, cognition, memory, or autonomy forms part of the Validation Object.

VDTS does not replace these architectures.

It consumes their relevant governed information where necessary and answers one validation-specific question:

What can the governed validation record legitimately conclude?

Why It Matters

The weakest point of many validation processes is not necessarily testing.

It is interpretation.

Organizations can perform extensive testing and still produce weak conclusions if:

- unfavorable results are discounted,
- missing results are treated as success,
- averages hide critical failures,
- uncertainty disappears,
- conditions are omitted,
- scope expands during reporting,
- conflicting evidence is selectively resolved,
- or a narrow validation becomes a broad claim of validity.

VDTS governs precisely this transition.

From Results to Governed Knowledge

VALIDOS® progressively transforms validation information.

The progression is:

Validation Object

→ what is being examined

Validation Criteria

→ what must be demonstrated

Validation Method

→ how it will be examined

Validation Evidence & Sources

→ what information may support the process

Validation Execution

→ what actually happened

Validation Determination

→ what the governed process demonstrated

This is the point where validation results become governed validation knowledge.

The Determination Boundary

VDTS deliberately ends before Validation State.

Its final output is not:

The object is permanently valid.

Its output is:

Given this Validation Object, Purpose, Scope, Criteria, Method, Evidence, Sources, Execution, conditions, limitations, conflicts, and uncertainty, this is what the governed validation record legitimately demonstrates.

That boundary protects VALIDOS® from collapsing validation conclusion, lifecycle status, and operational reliance into one ambiguous concept.

Foundational Principle

Validation results become a legitimate determination only when the conclusion remains bounded by what the governed validation record can actually demonstrate.

Canonical Closing Statement

Validation Determination Standard establishes the formal interpretive conclusion layer of VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture by governing the transformation of determination-ready validation results into criterion-level and overall Validation Determinations. Through result qualification, criterion satisfaction and non-satisfaction, conditionality, non-determinability, critical and mandatory criterion treatment, cross-criterion interpretation, conflict, uncertainty, aggregation, scope, depth, evidence and source-condition propagation, execution limitations, partial and hierarchical determination, authority, traceability, reassessment, suspension, withdrawal, and historical continuity, VDTs ensure that no validation conclusion can legitimately claim more than the complete governed validation record is capable of demonstrating.

Parent Resources

→ [VALIDOS® Architecture Map](#)

→ [VALIDOS® Complete Standards & Modules Index](#)

Related Documents

→ Validation Determination Standard

→ VALIDOS® Validation Governance Architecture — Validation Governance Layer

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